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The quest to create a \$1B startup with 10 people

By [Rosie Bradbury](#)

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Max Brodeur-Urbas' [Gumloop](#) has an ambitious goal: reach a \$1 billion valuation with just 10 people on its full-time staff. Right now, it has nine.

The two-year-old AI-enabled workflow automation startup, a [Y Combinator](#) graduate backed by [First Round Capital](#) and [Nexus Venture Partners](#), is taking the aspirational Silicon Valley concept of a "10x engineer" and extending it to its logical conclusion: Creating a billion-dollar company can be done with a few extremely efficient people.

When Gumloop raised a \$17 million Series A in January led by Nexus, it was just a two-man operation (plus two interns and two contractors).

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“When we did the Series A announcement, I was like, ‘I think we can do this with under 10 people’, based on the ratios of how many people we had at the company to output at that point,” said Brodeur-Urbas. He’s still confident, though now acknowledges “it might be a few more.”

Gumloop’s revenue is up to “several million a year,” and Brodeur-Urbas said the startup has received inbound offers from VCs for Series B capital while its seed and Series A money is all still in the bank, untouched.

The dream of an extremely nimble team hitting it big has long been a driver of the scrappy startup mentality—and AI has put it on steroids. Code-generation tools have accelerated “shipping” timelines, and revenue velocity for some of the AI hyperscalers has reached record highs. This week, “vibe coding” app [Replit](#) announced its annualized recurring revenue has jumped from \$10 million at the end of 2024 to \$100 million six months later.

The traditional playbook for selling to an enterprise involves an army of sales reps to lead demos and navigate the compliance-heavy sales cycle of the Fortune 500. AI agent upstarts want to upend that.

At Gumloop, Brodeur-Urbas does many of the demo calls by himself or with his one business development-focused coworker and markets the product on X and LinkedIn. It’s among a slew of AI application startups like [Sierra](#), [Clay](#) and [Zapier](#) offering new ways to automate business processes using AI.

Building a unicorn with 10 people is a particularly audacious ambition when selling to enterprises. Silicon Valley history doesn’t have a long list of companies reaching this level of success with a football team-sized employee roster.

Workplace chat specialist [Slack](#) famously eschewed hiring sales staff and paying for ads until around the time it was valued at \$3.8 billion.

Others have mostly been consumer apps, where the flywheel can be more self-sustaining.

[Facebook](#) acquired two-year-old [Instagram](#) in 2012 for a then-shocking \$1 billion in cash and stock when the image-sharing app had just 13 employees. Two years later, it paid \$16 billion for [WhatsApp](#), which had about 55 employees.

But this AI-powered, hyper-efficient startup won't arrive without hiccups. [Klarna](#), one of the first companies to try to fully automate its customer support, reversed course in a year.

"It's so critical that you are clear to your customer that there will also be a human if you want," CEO Sebastian Siemiatkowski said in a Bloomberg interview in May.

Acquisitions of tiny teams tend to happen early in a startup's life. Take longer, and the risk of burning out these employees goes up. Brodeur-Urbas has been spending late nights testing updates for Gumloop every weeknight. "I totally understand why companies hire a lot of people. I totally get it now," he admitted.

And this trend is compounding on [Silicon Valley's love of workaholism](#).

"The idea of running yourself into the ground or that the AI agents will magically do it for you is so intoxicating that people will pursue it, even if it means their business suffers," said [Sterling Road](#) managing partner Ash Rust.

"We have people right now who got from zero to six-figure revenue in a matter of weeks, and they will not hire folks, and I'm begging them to."

Featured image by Bertrand Guay/Getty Images

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About [Rosie Bradbury](#).

Rosie Bradbury is a senior reporter covering startups and venture capital for PitchBook News. Based in New York, she previously reported for the Bureau of Investigative Journalism, Business Insider and Wired. Rosie studied history and politics at the University of Cambridge.

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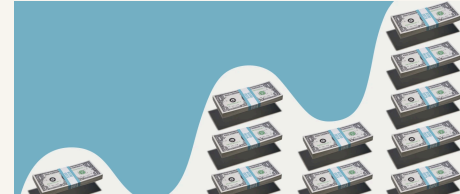


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